This happened sometimes when the river was flooding, so Master did not stop. We were going along at a good speed, but the moment my feet touched the ground the first part of the bridge, I felt sure that something was wrong. I dared not go forward. I made **a dead stop**.

"Go on, Beauty", said my master, and gave me a touch of the whip. But I dared not move. He gave me a sharp snap of the whip. I jumped, I jumped, but I dared not go forward.

"There is something wrong sir", said John. He got down from the cart and came to my head. He took hold of my **bridle** and tried to lead me forward. "Come on, Beauty. What's the matter?" Just then, the other man at the **tollgate** on the other side ran out, flashing a torch like a madman.

"Hoy, Hoy, Hoy, Stop!" he cried.

"What's the matter?" shouted my master.

"The bridge is broken in the middle. Part of it has been carried away by the flood. If you come any further, you'll be in the river!"

"Thank God!" said my master.

"You really are a Beauty!" said John, as he took hold of my **bridle** and gently turned me round. Of course, I could not tell him what the problem was, but I knew very well that the bridge was not safe.

The wind seemed to have settled down. It grew darker and darker, stiller and stiller. I trotted softly along, the wheels hardly making a sound on the soft, wet road.

Then Master told John that God had given people brains by which they can find things for themselves. He said, however, God had given animals a special knowledge which did not depend on thinking things out and was much quicker to respond to danger. This **instinct** in animals, he said, had often saved the lives of men.

John had many stories to tell of dogs and horses, and the wonderful ways they had saved the lives of people. He thought many people did not take very good care of their animals or make friends with them as they should do.

At last, we got back to Master's house. We saw that all the lights were on. As we came up to the door, Mistress ran out to greet Master.

"Are you safe, my dear? Oh! I have been so worried about you. Did you have an accident?"

"No, my dear, but if Black Beauty had not been wiser than we were, all three of us would have been drowned at the wooden bridge."

They went into the house and I heard no more. John took me to the stable. Oh! What a good supper he gave me that night. And then a really thick bed of straw. I was grateful for everything for I was tired.

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